job in Lucknow, Asghar returns to the town where Jaun and he grew up and fell in love with theatre as part of the college drama club. In this fictional place of Baansa, that could well be any small town in Uttar Pradesh, Asghar begins to rebuild his career, by going back to theatre, shunning the steady, middle-class life he had embraced to take care of his family.

With the dramatic turn of events comes a new beginning, as Asghar breathes life into the gentle bustle of Baansa, reinventing local theatre and its aspiring actors in a way the town has never seen. It plays out fittingly against the grating hustle of Mumbai, as Jaun's career moves in fits and starts and he scrambles to save what's left of his personal relationships. Wrestling with his ego and self-centredness but drowning in guilt and isolation, Jaun's efforts to win back his best friend are both humorous and moving.

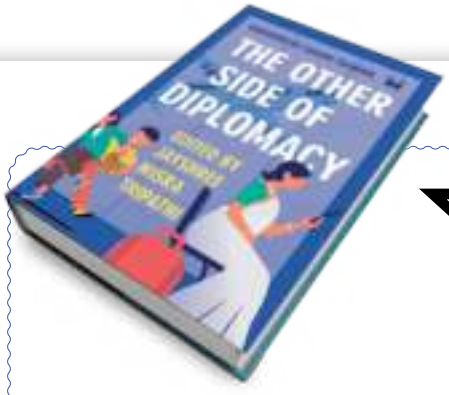
ANNIE ZAIDI populates the novella with a generous slate of characters, but there are no sidekicks here, and they all have a satisfying arc

Zaidi populates the novella with a generous slate of characters, but there are no sidekicks here, and they all have a satisfying arc, including Asghar's wife Zubi.

Though slim, *The Comeback* travels a full circle in a consistently engaging story that reads like it could be a lively movie (or a series?). Held up against Zaidi's other books, including the acclaimed *Prelude to a Riot* and her memoir *Bread, Cement, Cactus*, *The Comeback* can seem lightweight, but it is warm and large-hearted. Placing the story within the theatre and film world, an ecosystem Zaidi, who is also a playwright, knows well, gives it a raw and intimate quality.

The book examines the power of art and the disillusionment and hubris that come along with it. It also asks whether the compromises we make to cultivate a public image can become our undoing. If something good comes out of a betrayal, does it make it less of a betrayal? *The Comeback*, while stirring many such questions, is ultimately about a return to many things: to old friendships and true love, to the stage and the authenticity of one's art, to lost threads of the past and the warmth of childhood homes. There's a "comeback" in here that stings too, and also surprises. ■

—Neha Bhatt



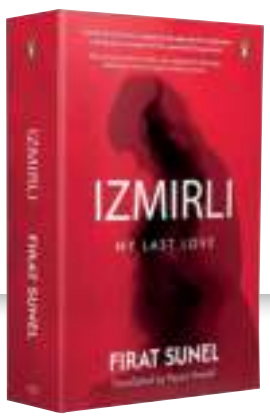
THE OTHER SIDE OF DIPLOMACY
Edited by Jayshree Misra Tripathi
WESTLAND BOOKS
₹599; 182 pages

The Better Halves

In this anthology of personal narratives, Jayshree Misra Tripathi compiles the recollections of her fellow diplomatic spouses. From Switzerland to Ethiopia, the stories collected here are windows into foreign cultures and, on occasion, offer a ringside view of historic events, like Kusum Tayal's account of a hearing conducted by then South African president Nelson Mandela's Truth and Reconciliation Committee (TRC) in the mid-1990s.

TWIST IN THE TALE

Eylül, a determined young woman born into a family of lawyers, moves back to Istanbul from Germany after her beautiful, mysterious mother Yağmur's sudden drowning, leaving her daughter with the family law firm and plenty of unanswered questions—for example, what is Izmirli and what role did it have in her mother's death? Former Turkish ambassador to India, Firat Sunel has written a gripping, cerebral thriller that frequently delves into the mechanisms of memory. *Izmirli* is the perfect read for those who like their mysteries with a slice of philosophical doctrine.



IZMIRLI
My Last Love
By Firat Sunel
PENGUIN
₹599; 648 pages

—Aditya Mani Jha